



REMARRIAGE AFTER DIVORCE

After a bitter break-up, the BJP and JD(S) bury their differences in their lust for power but the final word will be with the governor

■ By Stephen David

Once again, a marriage of convenience threatens to bloom in Karnataka. Less than three weeks after a bitter parting followed by some ungainly name calling, the Janata Dal(S) and BJP have kissed and made up to walk down the aisle to the Bangalore Raj Bhavan, to stake claim to form the government. The BJP chief minister aspirant, B.S. Yediyurappa, who even changed the way his name is spelt following advice from his numerologist, is hopeful of occupying the top office on the third floor of the Vidhana Soudha soon.

It was only on October 3 that the two coalition partners had traded charges against each other, submitting letters seeking dissolution of the

House and asking Governor Rameshwar Thakur to hold early polls. But there was a sudden twist in the tale as the estranged bedfellows made public that they had ironed out their differences and were ready to live happily ever after. What brought about this change of heart in the obstinate father-son duo of H.D. Deve Gowda and H.D. Kumaraswamy was the Congress snub to JD(S) president, Gowda, by not showing any interest in allying with his party for a second round of power in the state. Just a few days before JD(S) parted ways with BJP, Gowda had termed BJP as a "communal" party and announced to the world that it wasn't a safe idea for his "secular" party to join hands with it. To emphasise his secular stance, he had symbolically appointed a north

POWER PLAY: BJP workers stage a rally to show their strength

Karnataka JD(S) Muslim leader Merajuddin Patel as the party state unit chief. Even the 1,600 seats that the party won in the September local bodies' elections, the party topped the seats tally, followed by Congress and BJP that got 200 seats less, respectively, was attributed to the support from the 12-per cent strong Muslim population in Karnataka. Patel himself washed his hands off Kumaraswamy's "individual" choice to align with BJP. "We have nothing to do with a communal party," said Patel, who in a dramatic turn of events orchestrated by Gowda last week, accompanied his BJP party counterpart D.V. Sadananda Gowda to the governor's mansion to hand over letters of support to each other. The two also paraded 129 legislators, 16 more than the half-way mark in the 224-member House.

"Everything changes in politics, you cannot predict your moves," says Kumaraswamy, happily relaxing in a resort on Mysore Road, in Bangalore, with 49 JD(S) legislators, awaiting a call from the Raj Bhavan. "The governor is mandated by the Constitution to invite us. We are hoping he will call us soon," says Yediyurappa. But in the process,